

GALLANT IAS ACADEMY

PRELIMS CUM MAINS BATCH 2027

POLITY

MODULE 2.7

PARLIAMENTARY COMMITTEES

Parliamentary Committees are the **workhorses of legislative scrutiny**, doing in small groups what 788 MPs cannot do on the floor. Rooted in **Article 105** (Privileges) and **Article 118** (Rules of Procedure), they function throughout the year beyond the parliamentary session as India's '**mini parliaments**.' The Constitution makes mention of committees at various places without specific provisions pertaining to composition, tenure and function. The Rules of the Houses provide for committees.

CLASSIFICATION OF PARLIAMENTARY COMMITTEES

Category	Sub-types
Standing Committees	Permanent committees reconstituted every year. Include: Financial Committees, Committee to Enquire, Committees to Scrutinise and Control, Committees related to Day-to-Day Business of the House, Housekeeping Committees, and Department Related Standing Committees (DRSCs).
Ad Hoc Committees	Created for a specific purpose and dissolved upon completing the task. Include: Inquiry Committees, Advisory Committees, Select Committees, and Joint Committees.

FINANCIAL COMMITTEES

Feature	Public Accounts Committee (PAC)	Estimates Committee	Committee on Public Undertakings	Dept. Related Standing Committees (DRSCs)
Established	1921 under GOI Act, 1919	1950, John Mathai Committee	1964, Krishna Menon Committee	On recommendation of Rules Committee of Lok Sabha
Membership	22 members (15 LS + 7 RS)	30 members (Lok Sabha only)	22 members (15 LS + 7 RS)	24 Committees (16 LS + 8 RS) 31 members (21 LS + 10 RS)
Election	Elected by PR-STV	Elected by PR-STV	Elected by PR-STV	Nominated by Chairpersons
Duration	1 year	1 year	1 year	1 year
Ministers	Excluded	Excluded	Excluded	Excluded
Chairperson	Appointed by the Speaker from Lok Sabha. Convention: from Opposition.	Appointed by Speaker. From the ruling party.	Appointed by the Speaker from Lok Sabha.	Appointed by Speaker (LS committees) and Chairman (RS committees).

Public Accounts Committee (PAC)

Functions	Limitations
Examines annual CAG reports laid before Parliament by the President.	Not concerned with policy in totality.
Studies three reports: Audit Report on Appropriation, Finance and Public Undertakings (those not studied by COPU).	It is a post-mortem exercise.
Study is carried out from both a quantity and quality point of view.	Does not intervene in day-to-day matters.
CAG is the 'friend, philosopher and guide' of the PAC.	Recommendations are advisory; provide a report to Parliament.

Estimates Committee

Functions	Limitations
To suggest reform to estimates.	Examines budget after it has been voted.
To suggest alternate policies in order to bring efficiency and economy to administration.	Cannot question the policy.
Suggests in what form estimates should be presented to Parliament.	Recommendations are advisory; not every ministry is examined every year. CAG assistance is absent. Post-mortem work.

Committee on Public Undertakings (COPU)

Functions	Limitations
Examines reports on PSUs.	Post-mortem in nature.
Whether PSUs are functioning prudently and soundly economically.	Recommendations are advisory.
	Technicality is overlooked.

Department Related Standing Committees (DRSCs)

Functions	Limitations
Consider the demand for grants of concerned ministries (should not suggest a cut motion).	Does not intervene in day-to-day matters.
Examine Bills referred to them.	
Consider annual reports of ministries.	
Consider long-term policy documents.	
The Minister concerned shall make a statement once in six months in the House regarding the status of implementation of the recommendations.	

OTHER STANDING COMMITTEES

Committee to Enquire

Committee	Composition	Key Function
Committee on Petitions	LS: 15 members; RS: 10 members	Examines petitions on Bills and matters of General Importance on Union subjects.
Committee on Privileges	LS: 15 members; RS: 10 members	Examines privilege matters and recommends actions.
Ethics Committee	Formed in RS in 1997; in LS in 2000.	Examines Code of Conduct of members. Any person can raise a complaint.

Committees to Scrutinise and Control

Committee	Composition	Key Function
Committee on Government Assurances	LS: 15 members; RS: 10 members	Scrutinises assurances, promises and undertakings given by Ministers in the Houses.
Committee on Subordinate Legislation	LS: 15 members; RS: 15 members	Checks delegated legislation (rules, regulations, by-laws) made under Acts of Parliament.
Committee on Papers Laid on the Table	LS: 15 members; RS: 10 members	Scrutinises papers laid on the table. Does not check statutory notifications and orders (checked by Committee on Subordinate Legislation).
Committee on Welfare of SC and ST	30 members (20 LS + 10 RS)	Welfare of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes.
Committee on Empowerment of Women	30 members (20 LS + 10 RS)	Issues relating to the empowerment of women.
Joint Committee on Offices of Profit	15 members (10 LS + 5 RS)	Examines composition and character of committees and bodies on which MPs hold offices of profit.

Committees Related to Day-to-Day Business of the House

Committee	Composition	Key Feature
Business Advisory Committee (BAC)	LS: 15 members; Speaker as chair. RS: 11 members; Chairman as chair.	Recommends allocation of time for government and other business in the House.
Committee on Private Members Bills and Resolutions	Only in Lok Sabha; Deputy Speaker as Chair.	No such committee in Rajya Sabha - BAC carries out this function there.
Rules Committee	LS: 15 members; RS: 16 members.	Considers matters of procedure and conduct of business in the

		House and recommends amendments to the Rules.
Committee on Absence of Members from Sitting of the House	Only in Lok Sabha.	Consider all cases of absence for the whole of a session or longer.

Housekeeping Committees

Committee	Purpose
General Purpose Committee	Advisory committee; deals with matters not covered by other committees.
House Committee	Deals with residential accommodation and other amenities for members.
Library Committee	Assists in the use of the library and looks after the library building.
Joint Committee on Salaries and Allowances of Members	Frames rules for regulating payment of salary, allowances and pension to members.

Consultative Committees

- Constituted by the Ministry of Parliamentary Affairs.
- Committees attached to various ministries containing ministers and MPs; the Minister will head them.
- Cannot be considered as true Parliamentary Committees.

BENEFITS AND ISSUES

Benefits	Issues / Challenges
Expertise and Specialisation: Surrogacy Bill studied by Health Standing Committee; suggested altruistic surrogacy only.	Lack of Research Support: as highlighted by NCRWC.
Checks and Balances: Commonwealth Scam, 2G Spectrum and Coal Scam highlighted by Parliamentary Committees.	Lacks Independence: recommendations are advisory in nature.
Strengthening of Laws: E.g., Consumer Protection Act, 2019. Can gather inputs from experts.	Lack of Attendance: in committee meetings; shorter tenure of members.
Cross-pollination of Ideas: between ruling and opposition benches.	Non-referring of Bills: Farm Bills, Article 370 abrogation, CEC Appointment Act. Only 17% of bills were referred (vs 71% in 15th LS).
Scrutiny of the Budget: through DRSCs and Estimates Committee.	
Covers the Whole Policy Life Cycle and provides Public Engagement.	

WAY FORWARD

Recommendation	Detail
US Congressional Committee Model	Efficient committee, sub-committee and independent research system. Full financial autonomy. Continuity in committees is provided. Committees have the power to draft the bill.
System of Pigeon-Holing	If a committee disagrees, the bill dies then and there.
2nd Administrative Reforms Commission (2nd ARC)	Extend the tenure of committee members to a minimum of 2 years.

Woodrow Wilson on Parliamentary Committees:

"Congress in committee is Congress at work; Congress in session is Congress at public exhibition."

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS - PRELIMS

- Which one of the following is the largest Committee of the Parliament ? [2014]**
 - The Committee on Public Accounts
 - The Committee on Estimates
 - The Committee on Public Undertakings
 - The Committee on Petitions
- Consider the following statements about the Parliamentary Committee on Public Accounts: [2013]**
 - It consists of not more than 25 Members of the Lok Sabha.
 - It scrutinizes appropriation and finance accounts of the Government.
 - It examines the report of the Comptroller and Auditor General of India.**Which of the statements given above is/are correct?**
 - 1 only
 - 2 and 3 only
 - 3 only
 - 1, 2 and 3
- Which of the following statements about the Ethics Committee in the Lok Sabha are correct? [2024]**
 - Initially it was an ad-hoc Committee.
 - Only a Member of the Lok Sabha can make a complaint relating to unethical conduct of a member of the Lok Sabha.
 - This Committee cannot take up any matter which is sub-judice.**Which of the statements given above is/are correct?**
 - 1 and 2 only
 - 2 and 3 only
 - 1 and 3 only
 - 1, 2 and 3

4. **With reference to the Parliament of India, which of the following Parliamentary Committees scrutinizes and reports to the House whether the powers to make regulations, rules, sub-rules, by-laws, etc. conferred by the Constitution or delegated by the Parliament are being properly exercised by the Executive within the scope of such delegation? [2018]**
- (a) Committee on Government Assurances
 - (b) Committee on Subordinate Legislation
 - (c) Rules Committee
 - (d) Business Advisory Committee
5. **Consider the following statements about the Committee on the Welfare of SC and ST of the Parliament of India: [2026]**
- 1. Although members of this Committee are elected from both Houses of Parliament, the Chairperson of this Committee is appointed by the Chairman of the Rajya Sabha.
 - 2. Twenty members are elected by the Rajya Sabha and ten members by the Lok Sabha.
 - 3. No Minister, except for the Union Minister of Social Justice and Empowerment, is eligible to be a member of this Committee.
 - 4. Members are elected for a fixed term of two years from the date they enter their office.
- Which one of the following conclusions based on the above statements is correct?**
- (A) There are four correct statements.
 - (B) There is only one correct statement, that is statement 2.
 - (C) There are two correct statements, that include statement 1.
 - (D) There is no correct statement.

MAINS PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

- 1. Discuss the role of the Public Accounts Committee in establishing accountability of the government to the people. [10 marks] [2017]
- 2. Why do you think the committees are considered to be useful for parliamentary work? Discuss, in this context, the role of the Estimates Committee. [10 marks] [2018]
- 3. Do Department-related Parliamentary Standing Committees keep the administration on its toes and inspire reverence for parliamentary control? Evaluate the working of such committees with suitable examples. [15 marks] [2021]
- 4. Explain the structure of the Parliamentary Committee system. How far have the financial committees helped in the institutionalization of Indian Parliament? [15 marks] [2023]

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